The following subsections explain each layer, provide a policy example, and demonstrate how ACME applied these layers in practice.

15.3.1 Foundational security policies

Foundational policies form the bedrock of ACME's zero-trust security architecture. These policies often apply no matter who the principal is, what action they want to take, or which resource they are trying to access. In Cedar, this broad applicability is easy to recognize: The policy does not specify a principal, action, or resource details at all. The scope is intentionally left open, indicating that the rule applies to every request.

Foundational policies outline the minimum security requirements for the organization, including device posture, authentication strength, or enterprise-wide restrictions on sensitive actions. One of ACME's earliest foundational policies enforced device posture and authentication strength:

```
forbid(
    principal,
    action,
    resource
)
unless {
    context.device.posture.score >= 80 &&
    context.authn.mfa_performed == true
};
```

This policy doesn't specify the principal, action, or resource; it simply states that if the device isn't secure or the principal isn't properly authenticated, ACME won't authorize the request. When this policy first rolled out, Sam's team found that several internal tools still relied on unmanaged laptops, leading to an accelerated push for device enrollment. That experience underscored the importance of stating fundamental requirements clearly in the policy.

Foundational policies define ACME's non-negotiables. They establish the baseline conditions that every access request must meet, regardless of what other policies are involved.